

BRAZIL

THE LARGEST COUNTRY in South America, Brazil covers almost half the continent. From the 16th to 19th centuries it was ruled by the Portuguese, who named it after the brazilwood tree. The country contains deserts in the northeast, rain forests in the north and west, and rolling grasslands in the south. Because the climate is so varied, it is possible to grow almost any crop. Brazil has crowded modern cities – and areas that have never been explored. In the south, the forces of the Paraná and Paraguay rivers have been harnessed to form the one of the world's largest hydroelectric projects, the Itaipú Dam.

PEOPLE OF BRAZIL

The population of Brazil is a mixture of peoples. Some are descended from native Indians who have always lived in Brazil, others from the Portuguese who ruled there for 300 years. Many Brazilians have African ancestors who were brought over in the 17th century to work as slaves on the sugar plantations. At the beginning of the 20th century many Japanese sailed to Brazil to escape crop failures at home. Also during the 20th century, large numbers of European migrants settled in the south of the country.



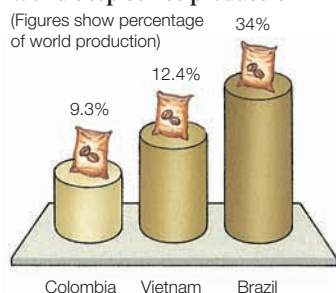
This Brazilian girl is of African descent.

This boy has both Portuguese and African ancestors.

The girl in the middle is a rain forest Indian from the Tembé tribe.

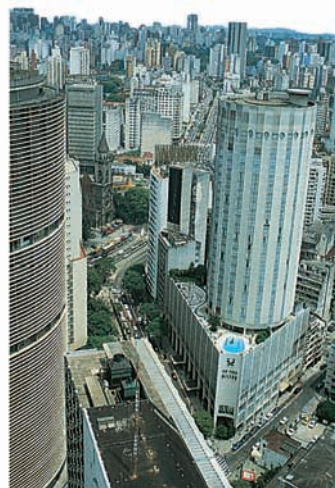
World's top coffee producers

(Figures show percentage of world production)



AGRICULTURE

Brazil is the world's major producer and exporter of coffee, which is grown on huge plantations, mostly in the states of Paraná and São Paulo. However, coffee is only one of the country's main crops; soy beans, sugarcane, and cotton are also produced on a large scale. Brazil is one of the world's main producers of oranges, bananas, and cocoa beans as well. About one-quarter of Brazilians work in agriculture, although the size of farms varies from tiny plots of land to vast estates. Many people work in the fields for little pay, while a few rich landowners benefit from huge profits.

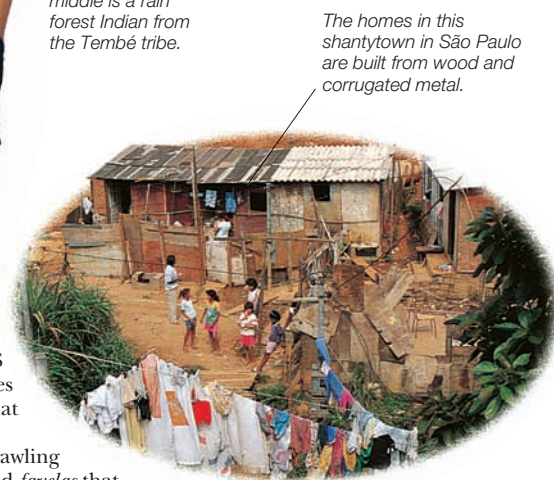


CITY LIFE

About 80 percent of Brazilians live in cities, most of which have developed near the coast. Over the years, many people have moved to the cities from the countryside in search of work and a better standard of living. For many years the cities grew rapidly, although this has now slowed down. More than 20 million people live in or around the city of São Paulo, more than the populations of London and Paris put together.

TOP CITIES BY POPULATION

São Paulo	10,677,019
Rio de Janeiro	5,974,081
Salvador	2,556,429
Belo Horizonte	2,305,812
Fortaleza	2,256,233



The homes in this shantytown in São Paulo are built from wood and corrugated metal.

SHANTYTOWNS

Housing shortages in Brazil mean that about 25 million people live in sprawling shantytowns called *favelas* that surround the cities. Most of the homes are built by the families themselves, sometimes from waste materials, but more often from wood, bricks, and cement bought from hardware stores. Services such as running water and sanitation are poor.

Favela homes



No running water: 70%



No toilets or drains: 60%



No waste collection: 52%



SOCCER

Everyone in Brazil plays or watches soccer, and there is a stadium in every city. The huge Maracana Stadium in Rio de Janeiro was built for the 1950 World Cup and holds 200,000 spectators. Brazil has won the World Cup more times than any other country, most recently in 2002. Many Brazilian stars play soccer abroad for teams in England, Spain, and Italy.